General Will

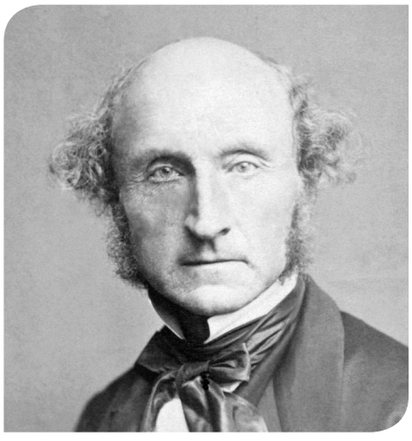
General will or the community is identical to the state. People submit their powers and personality under the command of the general will. The individuals wills are outweighed by the general will. Besides, sovereignty rests in the body-politic as a whole and it coincides with nothing, but the general will. Given the residence of general will in the community, it imposes the paramountcy and sovereignty of the people, i.e. popular sovereignty. He emphasises the transferability of power. The general will is not equivalent to the will of all since the former considers the common interest whereas the latter attaches private interest into its fold. There are two premises that determine the general will. First, it seeks general good, which refers to the objective of will. Secondly, it must come from all and apply to all, which proposes its origin. General will lacks representative character as the representative bodies have the tendency to develop particular interest of their own without paying heed to the concerns of the community. Ethical values and right consciousness do not coincide with the will of all. General will is invariably the manifestation of inner will and the product of conscience. Moreover, it is recognised as right, altruistic, universal and based on common good.

Assessment

Opinions are manifold about ***Rousseau***'s personality and works. G. D. H Cole opined about his 'Social Contract' to be "still far by the best of all text-books of political philosophy". Lord Morley took up different turn in expressing the status of ***Rousseau*** in the philosophical discourse by saying, "Would it not have been better for the world if ***Rousseau*** had never been born?" He tries to say that the awful experiences of the French Revolution could be prevented if ***Rousseau*** had not lived as the latter's ideas were fundamental throughout the movement.

His philosophy also traces a socialistic background. Capitalism received an "ill-treatment" in the hands of ***Rousseau***. He also favoured the nationalization of education and opposed the notion of private property. Besides, his discourse accommodates absolutism and authoritarianism as well. Under the pretext of general will, he is virtually favouring the "tyranny of majority". Despite all these, ***Rousseau*** deserves an irreplaceable position among the modern political philosophers.

7.8 John Stuart Mill (1806 - 1873)



Learning Objectives

- To understand the Political thought of ***J.S. Mill***
- To know about Critique of Utilitarianism, Liberty,

11th Std Political Science Eng Medium Vol-1 Page 171-205 Chapter 7.indd 125 2/6/2020 2:02:06 PM